

Conjure up an Update

Most of us tend to believe in not messing with whatever's working fine. Perfectly all right, but in the case of software that's not a very good approach to take. It is very important that you update all the software installed on your PC.

Some of the programs you need to keep updated at all times are Windows, Internet Explorer, Outlook and Outlook Express. These have a reputation for carrying a large number of security vulnerabilities. These programs can be updated from

the 'Windows Update' option in **Start > Settings**. This will take you to the Microsoft Windows Update page where you will be able to download the latest updates and install them.

Your anti-virus program is another important item you shouldn't ignore. Most anti-virus programs have automatic live update schedulers, which allow for automatic updation. Enable this feature and let the anti-virus do the updating for you.

installing Zone Alarm, a small message box appears near your system tray asking if you want the program to access the Internet. For example, when you launch Internet

Explorer, Zone Alarm will ask if you want Internet Explorer to access the Net. Click on 'Yes'. If you want the specific program to always access the Net, select the check box 'Remember this answer the next time I use this program' above the 'Yes' button.

Zone Alarm will also prompt you to set the program accessing the Net to act as a server. Be sure that this program is from a trusted source before allowing it to act as a server, because once you enable this option, it will allow others to gain access to your PC.

Click on the 'Security' button in Zone Alarm. Setting both local and Internet security levels to High ensures that your PC is invisible to outsiders. You can allow access to or block whichever programs you want to by clicking on the 'Programs' button.

Zone Alarm alerts you of potential hacking attempts and automatically blocks them. And the number of alerts you get, especially if you are using a cable or DSL connection, is unbelievable! This is because hackers usually run programs that send data packets to find vulnerable PCs, to which they can gain access. You can configure Zone Alarm to display a message every time you get an alert, or log them in a text file, or both. These alerts will give you details such as the IP address of the computer trying to access your PC, time of attempt, etc. An option you could use in Zone Alarm is to engage 'Automatic Internet Lock' when the PC is inactive for a certain period or when the screensaver is running. Click on the 'Lock' button in Zone Alarm to enable this feature.

So there you go! Follow these simple steps, and though they may not turn your PC into Alcatraz, you definitely will have some respite from nosy siblings, intrusive colleagues or malicious individuals on the Net. ■

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Remember to set local and Internet security levels in Zone Alarm to High

Prevention is Better than Cure

- Avoid running e-mail attachments.
- Use a separate ID when you post messages to newsgroups and other public forums.
- Do not make it a habit to sign Web site guest books, since this is an open invitation to spam.
- Most Web sites use small files called cookies, which are stored on your PC. These cookies send information about you to the sites. Use cookie removal programs to get rid of these.
- Use programs that clear the browser's history (sites you've visited) after every session.

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